

BREAK-UP OF KIDNAPPING CASES IN BIHAR IN 2009

	Jan	Feb	March	April	May	June	July	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
Kidnapping for Murder	7	11	6	9	8	11	4	25	5	18	5	10
Kidnapping for Marriage	78	78	111	100	100	133	163	123	111	102	128	110
Kidnapping Due to Other Reasons	118	131	158	125	154	167	174	161	151	104	97	146
Kidnapping for Ransom	8	7	4	3	8	8	7	7	10	8	2	8

Source: Bihar Police

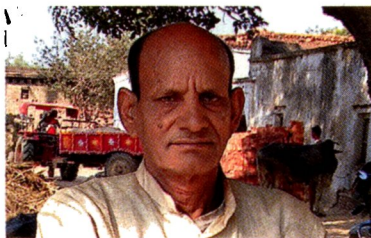
to well-off boys.

In the last few years, however, the increasing number of FIRs suggests that there has been a growing resistance to all such abductions of boys for marriage. In 2009, of a total 3,124 recorded abduction cases in Bihar, 1,336 have been bracketed as kidnapping for marriage. On the other hand, only eighty people were kidnapped for ransom in the state. Bihar's Additional Director General of Police, CID, Rajvardhan Sharma, however, claims that forced marriages are on the wane. "Sometimes even elopement cases have been registered as abductions," he says.

Abduction for marriage appears to have remained unabated in 2010 too. The records suggest that in January this year, 224 cases of abductions have been reported. While 87 of these cases pertain to abduction for marriage, only eight of them have been for ransom. In fact, abduction for marriage is not a new

“Almost 90 per cent of marriages in the village have been solemnised by kidnapping a bridegroom.”

KAMTA SINGH, *Chairman of a Primary Agriculture Credit Society in Rampur, Nawada*



trend, but what makes Bihar a standout case is the fact that here boys are abducted for marriage unlike in the rest of the country where it is women who are usually kidnapped. The National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) in India Report 2007 suggests that of the total 27,561 cases of

abduction reported across the country in 2007, nearly 47 per cent were for marriage. Of this only 5,174 were men. According to the report, 1,372 were within 10 to 18 years of age and 861 were below 15. And Bihar is also the only large state where more men (1,268) were kidnapped while the figure for women was 1,262.

Clearly, eligible bachelors continue to live under the threat of abduction for marriage. Many social thinkers attribute the persistence of this queer trend to the high number of dowry cases in the state. According to the NCRB report, Bihar has almost double the rate of dowry death against the national average of 0.7 per cent. "If you kidnap a boy, the bridegroom's family will know your muscle power and will never dare to torture the girl," says Jha.

However, beyond the statistics, hope never dies. With vermilion pronouncedly applied in the parting of her hair, 13-year-old Babita has started attending a school in Jehanabad where she studies in Class VII. She has already lost a year and with her father still absconding, appears worried that Prasad's family will be seeking to rescind the marriage. Just in her teens, her mind and her worries appear at odds. "I want him to honour the marriage," she says with an apprehensive look. In Bihar's backwaters, forced marriages usually survive because they often only thinly vary from arranged marriages, where too the couples hardly have a say. That perhaps is a bigger irony. ■



Photographs by ASHOK PRIYADARSHI

RAHUL, 18 Sixteen-year-old Banti (left) was married to Rahul, who is pursuing graduation. Rahul had gone to Rampur village in Nawada in the aftermath of a relative's death when Banti's father abducted him and forced him into marriage. Both Banti's and Rahul's elder brothers have been married the same way.